> had also suffered very severely from want of necessary food, cold and over-work, great was the delight of the sepoys at the prospect of being freed from so inclement a climate as is Kabul at this season, and the more especially as the whole of the firewood that had been laid in for the winter's consumption was already expended, and almost the whole of the fruit trees in Cantonments had also been cut and burnt.[21]

Lady Sale's final breakfast was cooked using the wood of her dining-room table. She then donned the turban and Afghan sheepskin *pustin* that her Afghan friends had advised her to wear, and, taking her twenty-year-old pregnant daughter with her, declined Captain Lawrence's offer of protection and chose to travel instead mixed up with the brightly dressed troopers of Skinner's Horse who made up the advance guard.

There was no sign of the escort that the chiefs had promised to send with the British. Nor was the hastily constructed pontoon bridge over the icy Kabul River ready in time to receive the troops, and they had to queue for an hour to make the crossing, despite Lady Sale's wounded son-in-law Lieutenant Sturt having spent the entire night 'up to his hips in water' sinking gun carriages in the river and topping them with planks. But to begin with, for all the delay at the bridge, and the confusion created by the thousands of frightened, starving and benumbed camp followers who for their own safety had deliberately mixed themselves up with the marching sepoys, it still looked as if the snow would be more of a danger to the retreating troops than the swords of the Afghans. 'It was bitterly cold, freezing hard,' noted George Lawrence, 'and I pitied from my soul the poor native soldiers and camp followers, walking up to their knees in snow and slush. It was no easy task to keep all my charges together, some of the bearers hurrying on, others lagging behind with the palanquins and doolies containing the women and children.'[22]

The first problem occurred just after eleven, when word came from Nawab Zaman Khan Barakzai that the British should halt their advance as he had not yet completed the necessary arrangements for their safety. By this time, the advance had at last begun crossing Sturt's makeshift bridge and a long and vulnerable line of troops were standing waiting in the cold snow between the river and the cantonment. Elphinstone, indecisive as ever, ordered a halt, then dithered on what to do next. Around the same time, a swarm of Afghans, including the absent ghazis, began to descend from the village of Bibi Mahru, 'rending the air with their exulting cries' and set about looting and burning the now deserted Mission Compound